Are Asphalt Shingles Failing in Wind? What Atlanta Should Know

The Asphalt Roofing Manufacturers Association completed a technical review of the Insurance Institute for Business & Home Safety's 10-Year Wind Performance of Asphalt Shingles report, the National Roofing Contractors Association reported in October 2026. ARMA raised significant concerns and warned against relying on that report for broad market decisions, citing non-standard testing protocols and incomplete modeling. For Metro Atlanta homeowners weighing a roof replacement in a region that sees heavy spring and summer wind events, the dispute matters: the material you choose and how it's installed drive real-world wind performance far more than any single contested test.

The short answer: A roofing trade group has formally challenged a widely cited wind-performance study on asphalt shingles, so Atlanta homeowners should base material decisions on proper installation and manufacturer guidelines - not one disputed report. **Who this affects:** Owners of 1980s-1990s tract homes in Gwinnett, Cobb, and Cherokee counties with aging three-tab or early architectural shingles approaching replacement. **What to do:** Schedule a professional roof inspection to assess current wind resistance and confirm shingles were installed to manufacturer specifications. **Timeline:** Before the next spring storm season, or at your next annual inspection.

Peachtree Roofing & Exteriors uses AI-powered drone inspections to document granule loss, lifted tabs, and flashing failures that affect wind resistance - details a ground-level glance routinely misses.

What Did ARMA Actually Dispute in the IBHS Wind Report?

ARMA concluded that the IBHS report's broad conclusions were compromised by testing-method problems, not that asphalt shingles perform poorly in wind. The trade group said IBHS evaluated 14 products across seven manufacturers but shifted testing procedures mid-project, used unrepresentative grab-sampling, and omitted positive performance outcomes along with enhanced manufacturer installation guidelines (Source: nrca.net, October 2026). For Metro Atlanta homeowners, the takeaway is practical: a laboratory debate over testing protocols is less useful than knowing whether your own shingles were nailed, sealed, and installed correctly. The actionable step is to ask any contractor how they verify installation against the manufacturer's published wind-rating requirements.

Why Does This Testing Dispute Matter for Metro Atlanta Roofs?

It matters because asphalt shingles cover the overwhelming majority of Metro Atlanta homes, and wind performance depends heavily on installation quality - a point ARMA emphasized when it noted the IBHS study omitted enhanced manufacturer installation guidelines (Source: nrca.net, October 2026). The region's April-through-September convective storms bring gusts strong enough to lift improperly sealed tabs, so the real variable for a homeowner in Marietta or Duluth is workmanship, not whether shingles categorically fail. Many 1990s suburban tract builds in Gwinnett and Cherokee were roofed with early architectural shingles that have since weathered past their sealant's prime. The practical move is to confirm your shingles still have active self-seal adhesion and proper nail placement - both of which a close inspection reveals.

As a GAF Master Elite certified contractor - a designation held by only a small fraction of U.S. roofers - and a CertainTeed Select ShingleMaster, Peachtree Roofing & Exteriors installs to manufacturer wind-rating specifications so factory-backed warranties stay valid.

How Does Shingle Age and Installation Affect Wind Resistance in Atlanta?

Aging shingles and shortcut installations are the two factors most likely to undermine wind performance - far more than the manufacturing quality ARMA defended. Asphalt shingles rely on a heat-activated sealant strip that bonds tabs together; as shingles age and granules shed, that bond weakens, and under-driven or over-driven nails leave tabs free to flutter in high wind. In Metro Atlanta's postwar frame homes around Decatur and Brookhaven, and in the dense 1980s townhome stock across East Cobb, deferred maintenance compounds the problem because minor lifted edges go unnoticed until a storm peels them back. This is precisely the gap ARMA flagged - real-world durability depends on installation guidelines the disputed study downplayed. Have a contractor check seal integrity, nail patterns, and flashing at every penetration before deciding whether to repair or replace.

Which Metro Atlanta Neighborhoods Should Pay Closest Attention?

Homeowners in Metro Atlanta's older and mid-era housing stock have the most to gain from understanding this debate. Across Gwinnett County - Duluth, Lawrenceville, and Suwanee in particular - sprawling 1990s tract subdivisions were roofed in a single wave, meaning thousands of shingles are now aging past peak sealant performance at the same time. In Cobb County and Cherokee County, including Kennesaw and Woodstock, similar suburban growth produced comparable roof-age clusters exposed to the same open-terrain wind corridors. Established intown areas like Decatur, Brookhaven, and parts of Buckhead carry older postwar frame homes where multiple reroofs over the decades mean installation quality varies house to house. In Fulton County's growth suburbs - Alpharetta, Roswell, and Johns Creek - newer builds may still carry original architectural shingles whose wind warranties hinge entirely on correct installation. The common thread is that a roofing company evaluating your specific roof, not a national average, gives you the answer that matters.

What Should Atlanta Homeowners Do Before Their Next Roof Replacement?

Treat material selection and installation verification as equally important, since the ARMA-IBHS dispute ultimately centers on how shingles are installed and tested, not on a single winning product. Request a documented roof inspection that assesses sealant bond, nail placement, flashing condition, and granule loss. Ask whether your contractor installs to the manufacturer's enhanced wind guidelines - the same guidelines ARMA said were omitted from the disputed study (Source: nrca.net, October 2026). If you're filing storm damage insurance claims after a wind event, photo documentation of the roof's pre-loss and post-loss condition strengthens your position. Peachtree Roofing & Exteriors assists homeowners through the insurance claims process and provides photo-documented inspection reports that give adjusters verifiable evidence.

How Do Housing Era and Roof Condition Compare Across Metro Atlanta?

Area	Housing Type / Era	Wind-Performance Implication	Homeowner Action
Duluth, Suwanee (Gwinnett)	1990s tract subdivisions	Shingles aging past peak sealant bond in sync	Inspect seal integrity before spring storms
Kennesaw, Woodstock (Cobb/Cherokee)	1990s suburban builds, open terrain	Higher wind exposure on aging architectural shingles	Confirm nail placement and tab adhesion
Decatur, Brookhaven	Postwar frame homes, multiple reroofs	Installation quality varies by prior contractor	Verify flashing and workmanship history
East Cobb	1980s townhome stock	Shared roof lines, deferred maintenance common	Check lifted edges and penetrations
Alpharetta, Roswell, Johns Creek (Fulton)	Newer builds, original architectural shingles	Wind warranty depends on correct install	Confirm manufacturer-spec installation

How Does an Inspection Settle the Question for My Roof?

A professional roof inspection resolves the uncertainty a national testing debate cannot, because it evaluates your actual shingles rather than a sample at a research farm. An AI-powered drone inspection captures high-resolution imagery of sealant lines, lifted tabs, exposed nail heads, and flashing gaps across the entire roof plane - the exact conditions that determine whether shingles hold in a gust. For homeowners in Smyrna, Vinings, or Sandy Springs weighing repair against full roof replacement, that documentation turns guesswork into a clear decision. Wells Fargo financing options are available for homeowners planning a roof replacement, so budget timing does not force deferred maintenance that erodes wind resistance. Ask for a report you can keep on file for both warranty and insurance claims purposes.

FAQ

Are asphalt shingles a bad choice for my home in Cobb County because of wind concerns?

No - asphalt shingles remain a sound choice for Cobb County homes, and the recent dispute does not establish that they fail in wind. ARMA's technical review challenged the testing methods behind a wind-performance report rather than conceding poor product performance (Source: nrca.net, October 2026). What drives real-world wind resistance is correct installation to manufacturer guidelines and the age of your current shingles. Have a contractor verify sealant bond and nail placement before assuming a material problem.

What does the ARMA response to the IBHS report actually mean?

It means a major roofing trade group formally disputed the broad conclusions of a widely cited wind-performance study on asphalt shingles. ARMA cited non-standard testing protocols, unrepresentative grab-sampling, and procedures that shifted mid-project. The group also noted the study omitted enhanced manufacturer installation guidelines that affect durability. For homeowners, the practical lesson is to prioritize proper installation and a current roof assessment over any single contested report.

How can I tell if my shingles will hold up in an Atlanta wind storm?

Check whether the self-seal adhesive strip is still bonding tabs together and whether nails were driven flush and in the correct location. In Metro Atlanta's April-through-September storm window, weakened sealant and improper nailing are the most common reasons tabs lift in wind. Granule loss is an early warning sign that shingles are aging past peak performance. A documented inspection of seal integrity, nailing, and flashing gives you a reliable answer for your specific roof.

Should I replace my 1990s roof in Gwinnett County even if it looks fine?

Not automatically - but a roof from a 1990s Gwinnett tract subdivision deserves a close inspection because many were installed in a single wave and are now aging together. Visible condition from the ground does not reveal sealant bond strength or nail placement, which determine wind resistance. If the self-seal strip has released on multiple shingles, repair may not restore reliable performance. Base the repair-versus-replace decision on a documented assessment rather than curb appearance.

Does installation quality really matter more than the shingle brand?

Yes - installation quality is a leading factor in wind performance, a point reinforced by ARMA's note that the disputed study omitted manufacturer installation guidelines (Source: nrca.net, October 2026). Correct nail count, placement, and sealant activation determine whether shingles stay bonded under gusts. A quality product installed poorly can underperform a modest product installed correctly. Ask your contractor how they verify installation against the manufacturer's published wind-rating requirements.

How should I document my roof before filing wind damage insurance claims?

Photograph the roof's condition before and after any storm, capturing lifted tabs, missing shingles, exposed nails, and flashing damage. Clear, dated imagery gives your adjuster verifiable evidence and reduces disputes over pre-existing wear versus storm loss. Drone-captured documentation covers the full roof plane that ground photos cannot reach. Keeping a recent inspection report on

file strengthens your position when storm damage restoration work is needed.

Will a new roof in Roswell or Alpharetta come with a wind warranty?

Yes - manufacturers offer wind warranties on asphalt shingle systems, but those warranties generally depend on installation to specification. For newer Fulton County builds in Roswell, Alpharetta, and Johns Creek still carrying original shingles, confirming correct installation protects that coverage. Factory-backed warranties through certified installers provide stronger protection than standard installs. Ask whether your contractor is certified by the shingle manufacturer, such as GAF or CertainTeed, before signing.

Is an AI drone inspection better than a regular roof inspection?

An AI-powered drone inspection captures comprehensive, high-resolution imagery of the entire roof, including sealant lines and flashing that are difficult to assess safely from a ladder. For homeowners in Sandy Springs, Smyrna, or Vinings deciding between repair and replacement, that level of documentation turns uncertainty into a clear, evidence-based choice. The photo-documented report also serves as a baseline for warranty and insurance purposes. It complements an experienced contractor's hands-on evaluation rather than replacing professional judgment.

Contact Peachtree Roofing & Exteriors for a free inspection.

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